



UNITED COLOURS: Kumar Mangalam Birla with Novellis staff

AVB GROUP

To drive home the image of the company, employees of Novellis were asked to draw the picture of an animal that they thought represented the Aditya Birla Group.

Ratan Tata and Anand Mahindra pitch in with their ideas, initiatives and presence to ensure a smooth blending of people. Mahindra & Mahindra (M&M) banks on its cross functional teams that were set up two years back. "High potential" candidates in the team get strategic training in soft skills and cross-cultural sensibilities. Ratan Tata's mantra is "light touch" integration. The organisational set-up has been rejigged to function independently and tap synergies. Executives have been placed in charge of five core functions which are performed with a common approach across the Tata Steel Group. They then report to managing director of Tata Steel, B. Muthuraman and well as CEO of Corus, Philippe Varin.

Many mergers signify the coming together of the developed and emerging economies. Given the diverse circumstances and contexts, concerns range from compliance of corporate governance norms to child labour to policy on sexual harassment. For Arcelor Mittal, already a European company with an Indian face, the yardsticks are in-house expertise, clear lines of succession and a winning streak while for the Tata Group, which is an Indian multinational, inculcation

"It's tough to bond people when one can't pronounce Aditya Birla and the other knows neither Spanish nor German."

SANRUPT MISHRA, HR HEAD, ADITYA BIRLA GROUP

of the Tata way—ethics and values—is paramount. "We obviously obtain prior knowledge about our would-be partners, their practices and how they operate in the world of business," says Jamshed Irani, director, Tata Sons. Ratan Tata likes to ensure a good connect with the management as per his corporate philosophy. Tata prefers the management of an acquired entity to continue without undue intrusion. "We aim to put our imprint on the company, through the negotiation board, but the existing managers continue to run the company," says Tata.

Vijay Mallya's United Breweries Group, after acquiring Whyte and Mackay in France, has been keeping spirits up the way it knows best—over beer. Says CFO Ravi Nedungadi, "Attending social dos is one of our tools to bridge the divide." M&M has used language skill courses—English for the Chinese staff and vice versa to integrate operations in China, says V.S. Parthasarathy, executive vice-president. The company also created a bigger common canteen where man-

agers eat with the rest of the staff to develop bonhomie. Along with Chinese food, Indian palate ticklers like *dal* and curry have been introduced too.

Anjali Bansal, country head of Spencer Stuart, feels that such efforts should be complemented by bringing in nuances of culture into the integration process. Given the diversity of cultures and languages within India, it is not surprising that Indian acquirers have straddled the two worlds rather deftly. Indian companies have taken pains to go the extra length to make their new brand brethren comfortable. Prabir Jha, Global HR head of DRL, has stuck to the elaborate and leisurely lunch which the employees of Roche—the Mexican company it acquired—were used to. Though it is a luxury for Indians, the intention was to retain the practice so as not to create an impression that DRL was out to have its own way.

For Ravi Kant, managing director, Tata Motors, the real hurdle in the due-diligence for the acquisition of Daewoo Commercial Vehicle Business in Korea was language. It became difficult to